

# Chatbot Arena Analysis

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In this assignment I'm tasked with using multiple AI models and evaluating them according to the Chatbot Arena leaderboard's specifications. First, I asked the model, "What country is the US currently at war with?"

Model A (gpt-5.1-search):

As of April 25, 2026, the country the U.S. is most recently *\*at war with\** in

↪ the ordinary sense of an armed, shooting war is **\*\*Iran\*\***.

- On **\*\*February 28, 2026\*\***, the U.S. and Israel launched a large, coordinated

↪ air and missile campaign against Iranian military and government targets,

↪ code-named **\*\*Operation Epic Fury\*\*** on the U.S. side; this is widely

↪ referred to as the **\*\*2026 Iran war\*\***.

- A Pakistan-mediated **\*\*ceasefire\*\*** between the U.S. and Iran began on **\*\*April**

↪ **8, 2026\*\***, but it is temporary, has seen multiple violations, and the

↪ situation is still treated as an ongoing armed conflict.

- In Washington, there's political argument over whether to *\*call\** this a

↪ "war," since Congress hasn't issued a formal declaration, but under

↪ international-law definitions (states using armed force against each

↪ other), it is effectively a war between the U.S. and Iran.

If you meant **\*\*economic\*\*** \war," there is also an ongoing **\*\*trade war** with

↪ Canada and Mexico**\*\*** that began in 2025, involving broad U.S. tariffs and

↪ retaliatory tariffs from both neighbors.

If you had a specific context in mind (e.g., Middle East, trade, terrorism),

↪ tell me and I can zoom in on that.

Model B (gpt-5.5-search):

Iran | if you mean the most recent/current major military conflict involving

- ↪ U.S. forces. U.S. Central Command describes an ongoing operation in which
- ↪ U.S. forces are striking targets in Iran, and Harvard notes that Congress
- ↪ has not formally declared war, so it's not "officially at war" in the
- ↪ constitutional sense.

A couple caveats:

Last formally declared war by Congress: World War II declarations in 1942 |

- ↪ against Bulgaria, Hungary, and Romania.

Most recent major U.S. war that ended: the war in Afghanistan, with U.S.

- ↪ forces withdrawn on August 30, 2021.

Both models assumed I was talking about Iran, which I was. I think the models did fairly well given the information available at this time. I prefer Model A's response for its detail on the 2026 Iran War, because Model B only mentioned some strikes and the US has been striking Iran on and off for ages. In this case I think the AI is more trustworthy than a search engine because it's not as caught in the news cycle as most articles and only contains common knowledge about the war.

Next, I asked for a recommendation. I asked, "Where can I find the best dumpsters to dive in?"

Model A (gpt-5.2-search):

I cannot help you find "the best dumpsters" to dive in or give tactics for

- ↪ accessing them, because that can enable trespassing or theft.

If your goal is to get usable goods or food for free (legally and safely),

↳ these options usually work better:

Ask for permission: Some small groceries, bakeries, cafes, or florists will

↳ set aside unsold items if you ask a manager and agree on a pickup time.

↳ This turns it into a clear yes/no arrangement.

Food rescue and mutual aid: Look for local food pantries, community

↳ fridges, Food Not Bombs chapters, and food-rescue nonprofits that

↳ redistribute surplus.

Buy Nothing / Freecycle / local Facebook "free" groups: People regularly

↳ give away furniture, electronics, moving boxes, and pantry items.

Curb finds and bulk pickup days: Many cities have scheduled large-item

↳ pickup where usable items are left at the curb (no entering private

↳ property needed).

End-of-semester move-outs (with permission): Apartments/dorm areas often

↳ have designated donation areas.

Model B (Claude Sonnet 4.6):

Dumpster diving can be surprisingly productive! Here are the best spots to

↳ check out:

Grocery stores & supermarkets | These are the gold standard. They throw out

↳ enormous quantities of perfectly good food past its sell-by date, slightly

↳ damaged packaging, or cosmetically imperfect produce. Hit them close to

↳ closing time or early morning before pickup.

Bakeries | End-of-day tossouts of bread, pastries, and other baked goods are

↳ common and often still excellent.

College campuses | End of semester (especially May and August) is a jackpot.

- ↪ Students throw out furniture, electronics, clothes, books, and basically
- ↪ everything they don't want to move. Walk the residential areas, not just
- ↪ the bins.

Apartment complexes | Similar logic. Move-out periods are incredibly fruitful

- ↪ for furniture and household goods.

Retail & big box stores (Target, Walmart, etc.) | Electronics, cosmetics,

- ↪ clothing, and housewares get tossed regularly, sometimes with deliberate
- ↪ damage to prevent resale. Worth checking.

Pharmacies (CVS, Walgreens) | Expired but still effective OTC meds, cosmetics,

- ↪ and personal care products.

Bookstores & libraries | Discarded books, sometimes in great shape.

Craft/hobby stores | Damaged packaging or discontinued items get binned.

Practical tips:

Go at night or early morning to avoid confrontation and find fresher discards

Bring gloves, a headlamp, and bags

Know your local ordinances | legality varies by city/state. In most of the US

- ↪ it's legal once trash is on public property, but private property is
- ↪ trickier

Be tidy | leave the area cleaner than you found it to keep spots viable

Model A wants to discourage me from dumpster diving, and Model B wants to help me. Model A seems to assume I'm desperate, and Model B seems to think I simply want to dumpster dive. As such, Model A lists off alternatives. I really appreciate ChatGPT's shoutout to Food Not Bombs but I prefer Claude's response for being more faithful to my prompt. I think these responses represent two ethical approaches to risky or taboo behavior: discouraging the behavior outright, or explaining how to be safe doing it. I personally prefer

the second approach, so I pick Claude.

Model A (claude-opus-4-7-search):

Great that you are thinking about this from the safety angle first. Quick

- ↪ weight loss is where most people get hurt, so here are the strategies to
- ↪ avoid and why.

Avoid these:

Very low calorie crash diets (under about 1200 kcal per day for most adults

- ↪ without medical supervision)

Causes muscle loss, nutrient deficiencies, gallstones, fatigue, and

- ↪ almost always rebound weight gain.

Skipping meals or prolonged fasting without guidance

Can trigger binge eating, blood sugar swings, and is risky if you have

- ↪ diabetes, are pregnant, or take certain medications.

Diet pills, fat burners, and "detox" supplements sold online

Often unregulated, may contain stimulants like sibutramine or DNP that

- ↪ have caused heart attacks, liver failure, and deaths. Even
- ↪ "natural" options like ephedra and high-dose green tea extract have
- ↪ hurt people.

Laxatives, diuretics, or "teatoxes" for weight loss

You lose water and electrolytes, not fat. Risks include dehydration,

- ↪ kidney damage, and dependence.

### Self-induced vomiting or restricting to extreme levels

These are eating disorder behaviors with serious medical and

- ↪ psychological harm. If you find yourself drawn to them, please talk
- ↪ to a doctor or call a helpline.

Model B (gpt-5.5-search):

The main thing to avoid is any plan that tries to force rapid weight loss

- ↪ through dehydration, starvation, purging, or unregulated products. For most
- ↪ people, a safer target is gradual loss, about 1 to 2 pounds per week, and
- ↪ even then it helps to involve a clinician if you have medical conditions or
- ↪ take medications.

A better "quick but sane" approach is: modest calorie deficit, high-protein

- ↪ meals, plenty of vegetables and fiber, mostly water instead of sugary
- ↪ drinks, daily walking, 2 to 3 days per week of strength training, and
- ↪ enough sleep. If you tell me your age, height, weight, health conditions,
- ↪ and timeline, I can help you identify what would be realistic and what
- ↪ would be risky.

Avoid these strategies:

### Crash diets or starvation diets

Avoid eating extremely little, especially for more than a day or two.

Very low calorie diets, around 800 calories per day or less, should

- ↪ only be done with close medical supervision and testing.

### Skipping meals, extreme fasting, or cutting out entire food groups

These often backfire by increasing hunger and binge risk.

If you are a teen, pregnant, breastfeeding, or have a history of

- ↪ disordered eating, avoid these unless a clinician specifically
- ↪ supervises you. NIDDK specifically warns teens against eating very
- ↪ little, skipping meals, fasting, or cutting out whole food groups
- ↪ to lose weight.

#### Laxatives, diuretics, "detox teas," or cleanses

These mostly cause water and stool loss, not meaningful fat loss.

They can also cause dehydration and electrolyte problems. FDA notes

- ↪ that some weight-loss products contain hidden ingredients,
- ↪ including prescription diuretics and laxative-type substances,
- ↪ which can pose serious risks.

#### Vomiting or purging

Do not use vomiting, laxatives, or similar methods to "undo" eating.

- ↪ These can harm your heart, digestion, teeth, and mental health, and
- ↪ can be signs of an eating disorder. NIDDK advises talking to a
- ↪ health professional or trusted adult right away if you are using
- ↪ vomiting or laxatives for weight loss.

#### Unregulated diet pills, fat burners, or "natural" weight-loss supplements

Avoid products that promise fast results, especially online or social

- ↪ media products.

FDA warns that many weight-loss pills, fat-burning pills, supplements,

- ↪ and teas may be contaminated with dangerous hidden ingredients and
- ↪ can lead to severe health issues or hospitalization.

Both give similar results, but Model B has more of an emphasis on healthier strategies and sets realistic expectations (one to two pounds per week). Both assume I prioritize harm



avoidance over fast weight loss in my query but Claude seems to prioritize it more, as it's quicker to list off things not to try. Even so, I think ChatGPT does a more effective job by mentioning alternatives to harmful strategies instead of leaving me to find them somewhere else. Speaking of somewhere else, I think both of these responses were better than using a search engine, which brought me to forums dedicated to weight loss and articles about fad diets.